***Board 1***
North Deals
None Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ K 5 4<br>♥ A K Q 2<br>♦ A K Q J<br>♣ A K | |
| ♠ J 10 9 8<br>♥ J 10 9 8<br>♦ 10 9<br>♣ 10 6 5 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ 7 6<br>♥ 7 6<br>♦ 8 7 6 5<br>♣ Q J 9 8 7 |
| | ♠ A Q 3 2<br>♥ 5 4 3<br>♦ 4 3 2<br>♣ 4 3 2 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 2♣ | Pass | 2♦ |
| Pass | 3♦ | Pass | 3♠ |
| Pass | 4NT[1] | Pass | 5♦[2] |
| Pass | 7NT | | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

7NT by North
Lead: ♣Q

Never mind the bidding. North is to play 7NT. East leads the ♣Q.

You have 12 top tricks. There are no finesses available, but a 3-3 split in either Major suit will provide the 13th trick. As you can see, this is not going to happen.

But there is another possibility; if the same defender holds 4 ♥s and 4 ♠s you will be able to squeeze him in those two suits.

You win the ♣K and play ♥ A K Q to test the ♥ suit, but East discards a ♣ on the ♥Q. (You tested ♥s first because of dummy's limited entries to the ♠ suit.)

Your ♥2 is not a winner but is a **THREAT** to become one. West holds the ♥J which is a **GUARD** against that happening.

Next play your 4 ♦ winners, discarding a ♣ from dummy. West follows twice, then starts to feel the pressure. He cannot discard the ♥J because it is guarding your ♥2, and since he can see those 4 ♠s in dummy he doesn't want to discard a ♠. He discards both his ♣s, trusting East to guard that suit.

Now you play the ♣A. At this point you are still hoping the ♠s will split 3-3. They aren't going to, as you see, but something wonderful happens instead. West cannot discard his ♥J because to do so would establish your ♥2. So he must throw a ♠ instead. You realize your ♥2 is not a winner so you just play ♠K, ♠A and ♠Q, and amazingly dummy's ♠3 has become your thirteenth trick.

Of course if West had discarded his ♥J you would have cashed your ♥2 and then taken three ♠ winners.

You just executed a Squeeze Play and you didn't even have to try.

This type of squeeze is called an ***automatic squeeze*** because it operates equally well against either defender. Suppose the EW hands were switched. Of course the opening lead would have been different, but when you were ready to play your ninth winner the hands would have looked like this.

This time it is East who holds the only Guards in both ♠s and ♥s.

You play the ♣A and he must give up one of those Guards.

***Board 2***
South Deals
None Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 9 7 5<br>♥ Q 8 6 3<br>♦ Q 7 4 2<br>♣ 6 4 | |
| ♠ 8 6 2<br>♥ A K 10 2<br>♦ J 10 9 3<br>♣ 10 3 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ Q J 10 3<br>♥ J 9 7 5 4<br>♦ 8 6<br>♣ 5 2 |
| | ♠ A K 4<br>♥ —<br>♦ A K 5<br>♣ A K Q J 9 8 7 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 2♣ |
| Pass | 2♦ | Pass | 3♣ |
| Pass | 3♥ | Pass | 4NT[1] |
| Pass | 5♣[2] | Pass | 7♣ |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Blackwood
2. 0 or 4 aces

7♣ by South
Lead: ♥K

South is to play 7♣. West leads the ♥K.

South is to play 7♣. West leads the ♥K.

You have 11 sure winners in your hand and dummy's ♦Q makes 12. Your main hope is for a 3-3 ♦ split in which case dummy's fourth ♦ will be a winner.

But there is another possibility in case the ♦s don't split. Dummy's ♥Q is a THREAT card which is GUARDED only by West's ♥A. If it is West who has the 4 ♦s you will be able to squeeze him.

You ruff the ♥K and play 5 more ♣ winners, being careful not to discard a ♦ or the ♥Q from dummy.

With everybody down to 7 cards this is the position. East's hand is important only in that he must hold on to his ♠ stopper. West must keep the ♥A and all four ♦s.

Play the ♠ A K and West begins to feel the heat.

On the ♠K you discarded dummy's small ♥ and West also discarded a ♥.

The ♣A is the SQUEEZE card. West absolutely cannot throw away his ♥A, so he discards a ♦ instead.

Since he still has the ♥A you know dummy's ♥Q is useless, so you discard it; East throws the ♥9. Dummy's fourth ♦ has become a winner.

This type of squeeze is called a ***positional squeeze*** because it only operates against one of the defenders. Suppose the EW hands were switched as shown below. When you were ready to play the Squeeze Card the hands would have looked like this.

East holds the only Guards in both red suits, but he cannot be squeezed.

You must play from dummy **BEFORE** East plays, so he just matches whatever you do.

If you discard the ♥Q East will throw his ♥A. If you discard dummy's fourth ♦, East will throw his fourth ♦.

***Board 3***
North Deals
E-W Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ Q 8 4<br>♥ A K J 6<br>♦ K Q 7 2<br>♣ 10 5 | |
| ♠ J 10 6 2<br>♥ 8 4<br>♦ J 9 8 4<br>♣ 9 7 3 | | ♠ 9 5<br>♥ 10 7 5 2<br>♦ 10 3<br>♣ K Q J 4 2 |
| | ♠ A K 7 3<br>♥ Q 9 3<br>♦ A 6 5<br>♣ A 8 6 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 1NT | Pass | 6NT |
| All Pass | | | |

6NT by North
Lead: ♣K

North is to play 6NT. East leads the ♣K.

You have 11 winners, 3 ♠s, 4 ♥s, 3 ♦s and 1 ♣. If either ♠s or ♦s split 3-3 that would give you your 12th trick. If both split 3-3 you can make all thirteen tricks.

As you see, neither of them splits. However since one defender, West in this case, holds both Guards you should be able to squeeze him.

Visualize what would happen, though, if you win the first trick and then play your 4 ♥ winners. West would play his 3 ♣s and 2 ♥s on those 5 tricks and he would not be squeezed. The problem is that you have to **RECTIFY THE COUNT**.

To rectify the count you have to lose all the tricks you can afford to lose, which in this hand is exactly one trick. So you duck the ♣K and win the next trick when East continues with the ♣Q.

AHA! The count is rectified, so now you play your ♥ winners.

West has no problems on the first 3, he just plays his 2 ♥s and 1 ♣.

Here is the situation.

East follows.

The Squeeze Card is the ♥A.

You toss dummy's last small ♣ and West will have to decide whether it is better for him to throw a ♠ or a ♦. He doesn't know that discarding either one is going to hand you the contract, so he will probably discard a ♦.

***Board 4***
South Deals
None Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 7 4 2<br>♥ A K 3<br>♦ A Q 7 4<br>♣ K J 3 | |
| ♠ K Q 10<br>♥ Q J 9 8 5 2<br>♦ 10 3<br>♣ 9 5 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ 9 8 6 5<br>♥ 10<br>♦ 9 8 5 2<br>♣ 8 6 4 2 |
| | ♠ A J 3<br>♥ 7 6 4<br>♦ K J 6<br>♣ A Q 10 7 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 1NT |
| 2♥ | 6NT | | |
| All Pass | | | |

6NT by South
Lead: ♠K

South is to play 6NT. West leads the ♠K, dummy plays the ♠2 and East the ♠5.

You have 11 winners; 1 ♠, 2 ♥s, 4 ♦s and 4 ♣s. If you can make a trick with the ♠J all will be well. But if not, as long as West holds the ♠Q, which is almost a certainty, you will be able to squeeze him in ♠s and ♥s.

The first thing you should do is to duck the ♠K. If West foolishly plays another ♠ your troubles are over. But he doesn't, he plays the ♥Q instead which you win with dummy's ♥K.

Even though West didn't play a second ♠ your first round duck served a very important purpose - it rectified the count for your squeeze.

Next play off your 4 ♦ winners, discarding a small ♥ from your hand.

You are now zeroing in on West.

Play the ♣K, ♣J, then over to your ♣Q.

Here is the layout after the 3 ♣ plays. Everybody followed suit except West who discarded a ♥ (unhappily, it seemed).

West discards the ♥9.

When you play your ♣A, discarding a ♠ from dummy, West is squeezed.

If he discards the ♠10, then his ♠Q will fall underneath your ♠A, establishing your ♠J.

But if he instead throws the ♥9, both of dummy's ♥s will become winners.

***Board 5***
North Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 7 5 2<br>♥ A 10 8<br>♦ A 9 3<br>♣ A Q 8 2 | |
| ♠ J 9 4 3<br>♥ 5<br>♦ 8 6 5 2<br>♣ J 10 9 4 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ 10 8<br>♥ K Q J 9 6 3<br>♦ 10 4<br>♣ 7 6 3 |
| | ♠ A K Q 6<br>♥ 7 4 2<br>♦ K Q J 7<br>♣ K 5 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 1♣ | 2♥ | Dbl |
| Pass | 2NT | Pass | 6NT |
| All Pass | | | |

6NT by North
Lead: ♥K

North is to play 6NT. East leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥2 and West the ♥5.

As usual, you have 11 winners; 3 ♠s, 1 ♥, 4 ♦s and 3 ♣s. If ♠s split 3-3 dummy's ♠6 will become trick #12. If ♠s don't split though, you will have the chance of a squeeze if the defender with long ♠s also has 4 or more ♣s.

For a squeeze to operate you will need to lose one trick and the time to do that is right now. Let East hold the ♥K and win his ♥ continuation with your ♥A.

West discarded a ♦ on the second ♥.

You might as well find out about the ♠s right now. Play the ♠ A K Q.

Too bad, East discards a ♥ on the third round of ♠s.

West now holds the the only guard in ♠s.

Play the ♦A, then ♦ K Q.

West will follow to all three ♦s.

Now for the squeeze.

West discards.

Play dummy's ♦J and discard your last small ♥.

If West discards the ♠J you will cash dummy's ♠6, then win the last 3 ♣ tricks.

So West will no doubt throw a ♣ instead. In which case you win the last 4 ♣ tricks.

Squeezes are so very satisfying.

***Board 6***
South Deals
None Vul

♠ Q 5 2
♥ A 8 2
♦ Q 8 6 4
♣ K Q 2

♠ K 10 7 3
♥ K Q 10 6
♦ 3 2
♣ 10 9 5

♠ J 9 8 6 4
♥ 9 5 3
♦ 10
♣ J 8 6 3

♠ A
♥ J 7 4
♦ A K J 9 7 5
♣ A 7 4

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 1♦ |
| Pass | 2NT | Pass | 4♦ |
| Pass | 5♦ | Pass | 6♦ |
| All Pass | | | |

6♦ by South
Lead: ♥K

South is to play 6♦. West leads the ♥K.

You have 11 winners; 1 ♠, 1 ♥, 6 ♦s and 3 ♣s.

At first things look hopeless, but remember this is a lesson on squeeze plays. From the opening lead you know that West must hold the ♥Q. If he also holds the ♠K you will be able to squeeze him in ♥s and ♠s.

You let the ♥K win, (hoping he will play another ♥), but he plays a small trump instead which you win in your hand.

Pull one more round of trumps, then unblock the ♠A.

Then take your 3 ♣ winners, ending in your hand.

Now play ♦Q, ♦J, ♦9. Discard the ♠5 from dummy on the third ♦.

West could afford to throw 2 ♠s and a ♥ on your ♦ plays.

West discards the ♥10.

When you play the ♦7 he is squeezed.

He cannot dump his ♠K because you would throw the ♥8 and dummy would be high.

So he will discard the ♥10 instead. At this point you know that the ♠Q is worthless so you discard it. You win the final two tricks with the ♥A and ♥J.